PreachingHub

SERMON INTRODUCTION WORKSHEET

The First Five Minutes

The best introductions aren't necessarily written first. Once you've studied the text, identified the central truth, and developed your sermon, you have a much clearer understanding of what your introduction needs to accomplish.

Your goal isn't just to capture attention. It's to:

01
Build trust

02
Introduce tension

03
Lead into the text

PART 1 Start With the End in Mind

Before writing your introduction, get clear on where your sermon is going.

1

What is the central truth of your sermon?

Write it in one clear sentence.

2

What felt need does this sermon address, and what deeper tension sits beneath it?

What do your listeners want, fear, struggle with, long for, or wonder about that this truth speaks to? Then go beyond the surface-level problem. What is really happening in the human heart?

EXAMPLE

The surface issue is busyness. The deeper tension is feeling like our worth depends on our productivity.

PART 2 Find the Connection

Help listeners recognize themselves in the tension before taking them into the biblical world.

3

Where does this tension show up in your listeners' everyday lives?

Think about their relationships, work, family, faith, decisions, disappointments, and desires. Then try to name it so precisely that someone thinks, "That's exactly how I feel, but I've never put it into words."

PART 3 Choose Your Approach

You know the tension. Now decide how to help people experience it, and how you'll lead them into the text.

4

Which introduction approach would serve your sermon best, and what specific story, question, observation, or image will you use?

What would accomplish the goals: build trust, introduce tension, and get to the text?

NEED IDEAS?

Flip to the first bonus at the end, **5 Introduction Approaches to Try**. It's not an exhaustive list, but it's a starting place. Get creative with it.

5

What were the original listeners or biblical characters experiencing that connects to this same tension, and how will you use it to bring your listeners into the text?

What similarities exist between their world and ours, even if the circumstances are different? Your listeners should recognize that the people in Scripture were wrestling with something deeply familiar.

PART 4

Craft Your First Five Minutes

Put it all together.

6

Draft your introduction, then cut what doesn’t serve it.

Write the bullet points of your sermon introduction. If you’re a speaker who uses a lot of notes, the introduction is a great few moments to have memorized (or close to it). Then read it back: does every part get the listener ready to receive the Word? Cut what doesn’t.

REMEMBER

Don’t start with what you want to say. Start by understanding what your listeners are carrying, and lead them to what God is saying in the text.

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BONUS · 5 INTRODUCTION IDEAS

5 Introduction Approaches to Try

Not a formula, a starting point. Each one is a different way to help your listeners feel the tension before you take them into the text.

5

1 The Uncomfortable Question

Ask a question that exposes a tension people would rather avoid.

EXAMPLE

"What happens when you do everything God asks you to do, and things still get worse?"

WORKS WELL FOR Faith · Suffering · Obedience · Disappointment

2 The Story

Tell a personal story, historical account, or relatable experience that embodies the tension before explaining it.

EXAMPLE

A story about getting lost even while following GPS directions, leading into the question of what happens when the guidance you trust seems to be taking you the wrong way.

WORKS WELL FOR Trust · Guidance · Uncertainty · Control

3 The Contradiction

Put two seemingly incompatible realities side by side.

EXAMPLE

"We have more ways to connect with people than any generation in history. So why are so many of us lonely?"

WORKS WELL FOR Community · Identity · Contentment · Relationships

4 The Shared Experience

Describe an ordinary moment that reveals something deeper about being human.

EXAMPLE

"Have you ever checked your phone for a response, even though you know there hasn't been a notification?" Explore what waiting reveals about our desire for certainty.

WORKS WELL FOR Waiting · Anxiety · Approval · Longing

5 Drop Into the Scene

Begin inside a biblical or contemporary scene without explaining everything immediately. Let listeners experience the problem before you explain the passage.

EXAMPLE

"The wine is gone. The wedding isn't over. And the servants have just been told to fill six enormous jars with water."

WORKS WELL FOR Narrative passages · Moments of crisis or surprise

BONUS · CLOSE THE LOOP

Close the Loop

5 ways to land where you started. A powerful conclusion often returns to the question or tension raised in the introduction.

NEW TO THIS IDEA?

What does it mean to resolve the tension?

Your introduction raises a tension. Your conclusion comes back to it. Resolving the tension doesn't mean tying a neat bow on every struggle. It means returning to the same question, story, or moment and showing how the truth of the text answers it, reframes it, or changes the way we see it.

The listener should feel the difference between your first five minutes and your last.

INTRODUCTION		BODY		CONCLUSION
Raise the tension	→	**Let the text speak**	→	**Resolve the tension**

5 Ways to Resolve the Tension

Each introduction approach has a natural way to land. Use these as examples, not rules.

	IF YOU OPENED WITH…		CLOSE BY…
1	The Uncomfortable Question	→	**Answer it**

Return to the question you asked and answer it in light of the text. Not with a formula, but with what the passage reveals about God.

EXAMPLE

You opened with *"What happens when you do everything God asks you to do, and things still get worse?"* Come back to that exact question and show how the passage answers it.

IF YOU OPENED WITH…	CLOSE BY…
2 The Story	→ **Finish the story**

Tell the first half in your introduction and hold the ending until the conclusion, or return to the story and see it with new eyes.

EXAMPLE

Return to being lost while following the GPS. What you needed wasn't better directions. You needed a guide who actually knows the way.

3 The Contradiction	→ **Resolve it**

Bring back the two realities that seemed incompatible and show how the truth of the text makes sense of them.

EXAMPLE

"More connected than any generation in history, yet lonelier than ever." Return to that contradiction and show the kind of belonging the passage offers.

4 The Shared Experience	→ **Reframe it**

Give the everyday moment new meaning, so listeners carry the truth with them the next time it happens.

EXAMPLE

"The next time you check your phone for a reply that isn't there, let it remind you of the God who has already spoken."

5 Drop Into the Scene	→ **Return to the scene**

Take listeners back to the same moment, now seeing it with everything the text has shown them.

EXAMPLE

Go back to the servants standing beside those six stone jars. Now we know what they were carrying, and who made the difference.

Putting It Together

One passage, start to finish: John 2:1–11, the wedding at Cana.

FIRST FIVE MINUTES

Drop into the scene

"The wine is gone. The wedding isn't over. And the servants have just been told to fill six enormous jars with water."

LAST FIVE MINUTES

Return to the scene

Back to the servants by the jars, vessels meant for ritual cleansing, now filled with the best wine of the night. Jesus doesn't just cover what's missing. He fills it with something better.

THE TENSION THAT TIES THEM TOGETHER

Running out at the worst possible moment, and the fear that what we lack will be exposed.

3 Traps to Avoid

✕

Introducing a new illustration in the last two minutes

Your conclusion should land what's already been built, not start something new.

✕

Recapping every point

A summary informs; a resolution moves. Return to the tension instead of re-preaching the outline.

✕

Ending with a to-do list

If the takeaway is just "try harder," the tension stays unresolved. Call people to respond to what God has done.

Your Turn

Apply it to the sermon you've written.

A

How does the truth of your passage address, reframe, or resolve the tension you raised?

B **Is there a way you could revisit the opening tension at the end of your sermon and show how the truth of Scripture changes our understanding of it?**

C **Does your ending call people to respond to what God has done, rather than just try harder?**